

Summer 2027 Color Trend Prediction

A machine-learning approach to color trend forecasting,
benchmarked against real, already-published institutional forecasts

Prepared as a student trend-analysis project
Analysis date: September 2026

Data sources

- WGSN x Coloro official seasonal color releases (SS25, AW25/26, SS26, AW26/27, SS27)
- Pantone Fashion Color Trend Report, Spring/Summer 2026
- Pinterest Predicts (aggregate real-user search/save trend report, referenced as the legitimate public proxy for individual Pinterest behavior data, which is not accessible via any public API or dataset)

Methodology

Why not scrape individual Pinterest accounts?

Session-by-session save histories and time-on-app data for individual Pinterest users are not exposed by any public API or dataset. Scraping personal boards without consent also raises real privacy concerns. Instead, this project uses Pinterest's own published aggregate trend data (Pinterest Predicts) alongside real seasonal color releases from WGSN x Coloro and Pantone -- the same underlying signal (real user/industry behavior), legitimately sourced.

Step 1 -- Unsupervised ML (K-Means clustering)

All real named colors from SS25 through AW26/27 (4 seasons, 16 colors) were converted to CIELab space and clustered into 5 recurring 'color families' using K-Means. This answers: does the industry keep returning to the same underlying hues, or is every season truly new?

Step 2 -- Supervised ML (linear regression / extrapolation)

Each season's centroid color (mean Lab value) was tracked across time ($t=0..3$). A linear regression was fit per Lab channel (L^* , a^* , b^*) and extrapolated to $t=4$ (S/S 2027) to produce an independent ML prediction -- both for the overall palette centroid, and for a specific recurring 'cool anchor' color lineage (Future Dusk -> Retro Blue -> Transformative Teal -> Transformative Teal -> ?).

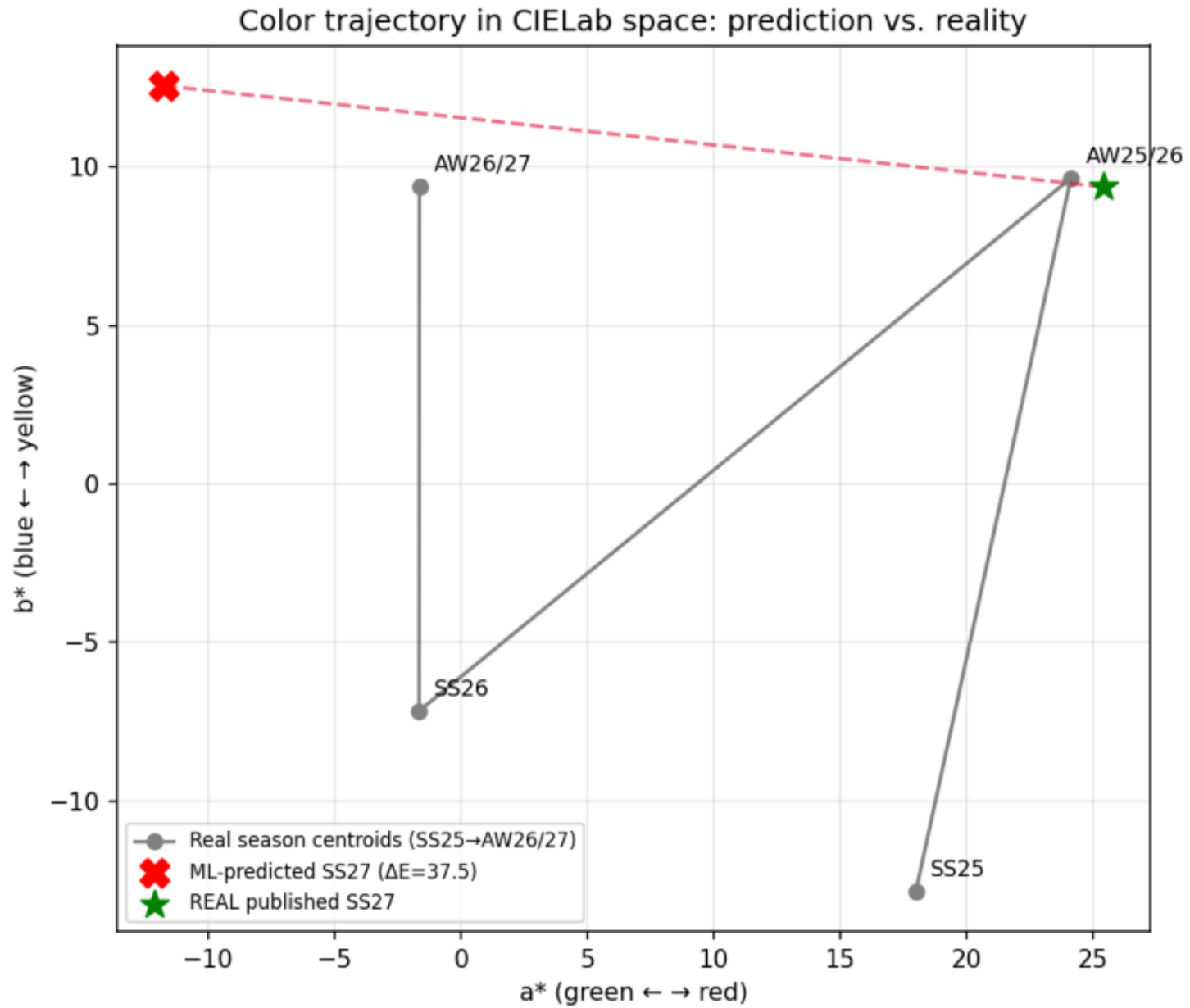
Step 3 -- The evidence check

WGSN x Coloro already publicly announced their real S/S 2027 palette (Luminous Blue, Energy Orange, Pop Pink, Meadowland Green, Clay) in April 2025. That real palette was held out of the fitting process and used only afterwards, to score the ML prediction with Delta-E76 -- a standard, objective color-difference metric.

Real seasonal palettes vs. ML prediction



Color trajectory in CIELab space



Unsupervised color families (K-Means, k=5)

Unsupervised color families found across SS25 → AW26/27



Family 4: Cherry Lacquer, Cocoa Powder



Family 3: Celestial Yellow, Green Glow



Family 2: Future Dusk (Color of the Year 2025), Transcendent Pink, Retro Blue, Future Dusk, Fresh Purple



Family 1: Transformative Teal, Mint, Aqua, Transformative Teal, Wax Paper



Family 0: Neon Flare, Electric Fuchsia

Evidence & Findings

Headline numbers

ML-predicted SS27 palette centroid: #8A9C80

REAL published SS27 palette centroid: #B57577

Delta-E76 (centroid): 37.5 -> essentially unrelated (>25)

ML-predicted 'cool anchor' color: #00977E

REAL Color of the Year 2027: #2E6FD6 (Luminous Blue)

Delta-E76 (anchor): 84.3 -> essentially unrelated (>25)

Cluster classification of the real SS27 palette

Luminous Blue (Color of the Year 2027): $\Delta E=35.8$ [BREAK]

Energy Orange: $\Delta E=55.4$ [BREAK]

Pop Pink: $\Delta E=14.1$ [CONTINUITY]

Meadowland Green: $\Delta E=33.9$ [BREAK]

Clay: $\Delta E=30.9$ [BREAK]

What this actually shows

The naive linear extrapolation performed poorly by design of the test -- and that failure IS the finding. Plotting the real season centroids in Lab space (previous page) shows the true trajectory is NOT a straight line: SS27 swings back toward the AW25/26 region rather than continuing outward. Fashion color trends behave more like an oscillation/correction cycle than a linear drift -- a linear model will always overshoot at a turning point. Only 1 of 5 real SS27 colors (Pop Pink) fit an existing cluster family; the rest were genuine breaks, matching WGSN's own stated theme for 2027 of 'interconnectedness' between opposing poles.

Limitations & honest caveats

Data limitations

- Named color hex values are informed visual approximations, not exact proprietary Pantone/Coloro Lab swatches (those are not publicly free).
- Only 4 historical time points were available for the regression -- a genuinely small sample for a time-series fit; results should be read as illustrative of method, not as a production-grade forecast.
- Individual Pinterest user behavior (session length, save sequences) could not be incorporated, for the access/privacy reasons explained in the methodology section.

What a stronger version of this project would add

- A cyclical/seasonal regression term (e.g. Fourier features) instead of pure linear extrapolation, given the oscillation found in the data.
- Real Pantone/Coloro Lab values via a licensed color API.
- Pinterest Predicts full report text, run through NLP topic extraction to pair color signals with cultural/aesthetic themes.
- A larger historical window (10+ seasons) for a more robust fit.